

Tashfeen Mehmood

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Dear Members of the Selection Committee,

I am writing to apply for the Einstein Fellowship to develop and advance my proposed research project titled “*Code, Conflict, and Control: Who Shapes the Stories AI Tells.*” My work lies at the intersection of artificial intelligence, narrative systems, and socio-political structures, with a focus on how AI systems influence, reproduce, and potentially reshape contested narratives in times of conflict.

As a software engineer and AI practitioner, I have gained hands-on experience in developing machine learning models, data-driven systems, and full-stack applications. In my role as an Automated Machine Learning Engineer at the Technical Education and Vocational Training Authority (TEVTA), I worked on designing and deploying AI models using Python and Azure, while also handling data preprocessing, model optimization, and workflow automation. These experiences strengthened my technical foundation and deepened my interest in the real-world implications of AI systems beyond their technical performance.

Alongside my technical work, I have developed a strong research interest in the socio-political dimensions of artificial intelligence. I am particularly concerned with the assumption of “neutrality” in AI systems and how training data, institutional power structures, and historical narratives shape algorithmic outputs. My proposed project critically examines how AI systems may unintentionally reinforce dominant narratives during periods of conflict, and how such systems contribute to the construction of perceived “truth” in digital environments.

The Einstein Fellowship provides a unique intellectual environment to pursue this interdisciplinary inquiry. I am especially drawn to its emphasis on independent, cross-disciplinary research that bridges science, society, and critical thought. I aim to combine technical AI analysis with perspectives from media studies, political theory, and ethics to investigate who controls narrative generation in AI systems and what forms of bias or structural influence are embedded within them.

In addition, I am currently learning German (A2 level) and intend to further integrate into the academic and research culture in Germany. I see this fellowship as an opportunity not only to refine my research but also to contribute meaningfully to discussions on responsible AI, information integrity, and digital power structures.

I would be honored to have the opportunity to develop this project under the Einstein Fellowship and contribute to its tradition of fostering innovative and impactful research.

Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,
Tashfeen Mehmood